Of the three causal drivers of India's Afghanistan policy—striking a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, evolving international political environment, and the changing nature of Afghan domestic politics—the second became paramount in the 1980s. India's notion of a non-aligned foreign policy became void as relations with the Soviet Union were given primacy during the 1980s. As a frustrated Congress (I) MP, P. N. Sukul, stated in a parliamentary debate, despite leading the non-aligned movement, India could not be equidistant from both the US and the USSR. 'How can we have equidistance? We have our own perceptions, which differ from country to country. There are countries that have helped us, who help us. In spite of this policy of non-alignment, how can we keep ourselves equidistant from the friends and foes, both? That is why, on the basis of our own experience, we have developed our friendship with certain nations, certain countries who do not want to destabilise us, who do not create problems for us but rather help and have helped us' he said.[151] The problem in Afghanistan, however, was different. India had ended up on the losing side.

In February 1989, the Peshawar-based Islamic Unity of the Afghan Mujahideen was recognised as Afghanistan's government-in-exile by Pakistan and Saudi Arabia. India maintained that it had no relations with this interim government. But a new international consensus was emerging under the leadership of the US that legitimised the Mujahideen.[152] Opposing Washington's support to the Mujahideen, in May 1990, EAM I. K. Gujral categorically informed Indian parliamentarians that 'India and USA have different views regarding political settlement of Afghanistan'.[153] Such a stance came under severe strain as Najibullah's grip on Kabul eroded further (as reflected in the March 1990 coup attempt by Tanai). Regardless of active diplomacy with the US and the USSR and the exploration of different diplomatic and coercive options vis-à-vis Pakistan, India was unable to carve out a strategically sound policy towards Afghanistan as the Soviet Union withdrew its forces in 1989. According to some scholars, India's continuing support to Najibullah even after 1989 was a natural policy because he was vehemently anti-Pakistan.[154] As this chapter shows, India's obsession with Najibullah was not as much about effective strategy formation as much it was about clinging to a failing but friendly regime with the false hope that things would change for the better. What is interesting, however, is the